CONNECT WEEKLY

Issue 08 · week ending Friday 30 October 2026
themapsproject.com

A weekly review of national and South Yorkshire developments in education policy, inclusion, SEND, behaviour and accountability — weighted to primary and evidence sources, with links and a clear "so what for your school" line on the items that matter.

Useful? Forward it to a colleague. To join the circulation or partner with the network, get in touch.

TOP LINE

- Chancellor John Healey delivered his first Autumn Budget on Wednesday 28 October, and it landed light for schools: no new core funding grant, and the OBR's own forecast flags councils' cumulative SEND overspend reaching roughly £5.7bn by 2027-28 (a directional figure, not a confirmed exact one). The two confirmed education lines were a £60m-a-year uplift for PE and school sport partnerships, and up to £5m a year for three years from 2027-28 to get more books to pre-school children.

  → **For your school:** *Don't build budget-planning assumptions on today's commentary — wait for the DfE's own schools-funding breakdown of the settlement before adjusting any forecasts.*

- The Local Government Association's post-Budget briefing welcomes the already-announced 90% write-off of historic council SEND deficits, but says the Budget gave no clarity on how deficits building up in 2026-27 and 2027-28 will be handled once the Dedicated Schools Grant accounting override ends in 2028. Separately, some councils' write-offs are still being finalised rather than banked.

  → **For your school:** *If your trust works closely with Sheffield City Council on SEND placements or EHCP funding, it's worth asking where the council's own deficit write-off stands before assuming the financial pressure has eased.*

- The DfE has opened a call for evidence on exclusion reform, covering a time-limited internal suspension framework, formal reintegration-support partnerships after a suspension, and the day-one schoolwork duty flagged in last week's edition. It closes 19 November.

  → **For your school:** *Worth a look from whoever leads your behaviour policy — this is the detail stage of reforms that could reshape how suspensions and reintegration work, and responding now is the way to influence the final shape.*

- A genuinely quiet week nationally for Ofsted and safeguarding specifically, and Sheffield schools have been shut for half term since Monday — so this edition is lighter than usual on those two beats rather than padded out.

  → **For your school:** *No action needed — a reasonable week to catch up on the exclusion reform call for evidence or the Budget detail instead.*

DATES FOR THE DIARY

6 Nov 2026 — Deadline to notify the DfE of high needs place changes for 2027-28 funding allocations.

11 Nov 2026 — 5pm deadline for Care to Learn and 16-19 Bursary Fund claim forms, per the DfE's 30 September Update.

19 Nov 2026 — DfE's call for evidence on exclusion reform (internal suspension, reintegration partnerships, day-one schoolwork) closes.

15 Dec 2026 — NEU's formal strike ballot of teachers and support staff over pay, funding and workload closes.

NATIONAL POLICY

- **Budget lands light for schools, with the SEND funding gap the real story.** Chancellor John Healey's first Budget included few schools-specific announcements beyond the £60m-a-year PE and school sport uplift and the £15m pre-school books commitment. The bigger signal was the OBR's own forecast of a widening council SEND deficit, and commentary that mainstream per-pupil funding is on track to fall in real terms as funding is held flat against falling pupil numbers, with no new grant confirmed to cover schools' rising minimum-wage costs. It's the first full fiscal event under Education Secretary Lucy Powell, who took over from Bridget Phillipson in the summer reshuffle that also brought in Healey as Chancellor. (Tes)

  → **For your school:** *Hold off on budget-planning assumptions until the DfE publishes its own schools-funding breakdown of this settlement, expected in the coming weeks.*

FUNDING

- **SEND deficit write-off welcomed, but the next two years are still unresolved.** The LGA's Autumn Budget briefing says councils welcomed the previously-announced 90% write-off of historic Dedicated Schools Grant deficits, but is disappointed there's no clarity in this Budget on how deficits accruing in 2026-27 and 2027-28 will be addressed before the accounting override ends in 2028. Separately, councils are reportedly unhappy that surpluses in other DSG blocks will offset their deficits in practice, meaning some will see less than a full 90% write-off — and a number of councils won't have their deficits written off this autumn at all because their SEND reform plans need more work. It's the same structural problem the Budget was meant to start answering, and didn't. (Local Government Association)

  → **For your school:** *Worth checking directly with Sheffield City Council's finance team where its own write-off and SEND reform plan stand, rather than assuming national coverage reflects the local position.*

INCLUSION, SEND & BEHAVIOUR

- **Exclusion reform moves from consultation to call for evidence.** The DfE has opened a formal call for evidence on three proposals trailed in the Schools White Paper: a time-limited internal suspension framework that keeps pupils on-site rather than sending them home, formal reintegration-support partnerships with an agreed plan after a suspension, and the day-one schoolwork duty covered in last week's edition. It closes 19 November. A charity response from Contact has already flagged that most exclusions are linked to needs not being properly supported, and says it will push for the reforms to work for children with SEND specifically — a reminder that behaviour and SEND policy are, in practice, the same conversation. (GOV.UK)

  → **For your school:** *If your school or trust has a view on internal suspension or reintegration practice, this is the window to feed it in before the policy hardens — treat current proposals as indicative, not settled.*

OFSTED & ACCOUNTABILITY

- **Quiet week — nothing new and reliably dated surfaced nationally.** No fresh Ofsted policy announcement or framework change was reliably dated to this week in our searches. We're flagging the quiet week rather than reaching back into older Big Listen or report-card coverage to pad this section out. (Editorial note)

  → **For your school:** *No action needed this week.*

SAFEGUARDING & WELLBEING

- **Quiet week nationally on safeguarding specifically.** Nothing new and reliably dated on safeguarding policy surfaced this week beyond the ongoing NEU formal strike ballot over pay, funding and workload, which closes 15 December and sits as much in the wellbeing and workload space as in industrial relations (see diary). KCSIE 2026 remains in effect since 1 September with no amendments reported. (NEU)

  → **For your school:** *Worth keeping half an eye on the NEU ballot outcome in December, given the direct read-across to staff workload and wellbeing conversations in your own setting.*

SHEFFIELD & SOUTH YORKSHIRE

▪ **A strong set of local Ofsted results, but half term keeps the wider picture quiet.** The Star's latest round-up reports ten Sheffield schools and nurseries praised in reports published across September and October, including High Storrs School's top grade in all seven areas and Bright Horizons Millhouses Day Nursery matching it. Beyond that, the city's schools have been closed for the autumn half term since Monday 26 October, returning 2 November, so no new city-level education story broke this week. Last week's unresolved Firth Park Academy funding decision still has no published outcome in our searches. (The Star)

→ **For your school:** *If you need the Firth Park funding outcome, it's still worth checking directly with the council rather than waiting for it to surface in press coverage.*

FROM THE CORRIDOR

A Budget with two schools-specific lines and one eight-figure SEND deficit forecast tells you where the real pressure sits this year.

Editor's note

MAPS IN PRACTICE – TOOL SPOTLIGHT: SCHOOL+

A strong inclusion strategy is only as good as the cohort picture beneath it.

School+ is the MAPs cohort-vulnerability framework — it maps who your at-risk pupils are and why, giving your inclusion strategy an evidence base rather than a wish list. Explore School+

SOURCES MONITORED

Weighted official- and evidence-first. X is monitored for early signals from official accounts and named commentators, and corroborated against a primary source before anything is included.

Source	Type	What we track
OFFICIAL & STATUTORY		
DfE / GOV.UK	Government	Policy, funding, statutory guidance and statistics
Ofsted	Government	Inspection framework, report cards, annual report
Explore Education Statistics	Government data	Exclusions, suspensions, attendance, census data
House of Commons Library	Parliament	Neutral briefings on bills and policy
RESEARCH & EVIDENCE		
Education Endowment Foundation	Research	Evidence-based guidance, incl. inclusive teaching
NFER	Research	Assessment, workforce, disadvantage
Education Policy Institute	Think tank	Policy analysis and the disadvantage gap
Institute for Fiscal Studies	Think tank	School funding and spending analysis
FFT Education Datalab	Data analysis	Data-driven analysis of attainment and exclusions
INCLUSION & PREVENTION SPECIALISTS		
The Difference	Charity	Whole-school inclusion; "Who's Losing Learning?"
IPPR	Think tank	Lost learning, exclusions, SEND reform
Youth Endowment Fund	Research	What works to prevent youth violence & exclusion
Centre for Social Justice	Think tank	Exclusion tracker and social-mobility policy
Whole School SEND	Network	SEND practice, resources and reviews
SECTOR PRESS & COMMENTARY		
Schools Week	Press	Breaking sector news and investigations
Tes	Press	Practice, policy and workforce
The Guardian (Education)	Press	National coverage and comment
X (monitored)	Social	DfE, Ofsted, EEF and named voices — corroborated before use
LOCAL & REGIONAL		
The Star (Sheffield)	Local press	Local schools and Ofsted outcomes

Source	Type	What we track
Sheffield City Council	Local government	Council decisions, funding and local strategy
South Yorkshire MCA & Careers Hub	Regional	Regional skills, careers and funding

Connect Weekly is part of Sheffield Connect. Compiled by Andy Marsden, Sector Inclusion Lead.

For circulation across the network and partners. Figures reflect the latest published data at the date of this brief.